



had sent letters expressing their willingness to hold the matches with some changes in the schedule. All the changes had been made by the IPL in the last schedule it submitted to the Government. They were made to come up with a re-worked schedule thrice but received no clear response from the Government.

It seems that the home minister was not too keen on the tournament from the start. Sources said that he was miffed over the fact that the IPL did not consult the ministry before announcing the dates. He felt that the organisers were taking the Government for granted. "Lalit Modi sent several requests to meet him but the minister turned them down, saying that he should seek an appointment with home secretary Madhukar Gupta," said a senior Home Ministry official.

The attack on Sri Lankan cricketers in Lahore came as a timely excuse for the Home Ministry to hammer the final nail. The security reasons may have been genuine but it was widely seen as yielding ground to terrorists and gave the Government's political opponents a convenient handle. On March 3, hours after the attack, Chidambaram told a TV channel that, he was 'concerned' that the Lahore attack could spill into India and suggested that the IPL be postponed. That was enough to kick up a political storm. Narendra Modi called it

**ELECTORAL POLITICS
FORCED A FACE-OFF
BETWEEN MODI AND
CHIDAMBARAM (LEFT)
OVER SECURITY ISSUES**



“It's another opportunity for South Africa to showcase its beauty. It will be a huge spectacle, one of the biggest we've ever seen.”

**GRAEME SMITH,
Rajasthan Royals**

a 'national shame' and offered to host IPL-2 in Gujarat. The BJP said that Chidambaram had created an impression that India was not a safe destination for sporting events and it would send wrong signals to the world before the 2010 Commonwealth Games.

The issue was politicised even more when it was revealed that the NDA-ruled states like Gujarat, Karnataka and Chhattisgarh had assured full security for the IPL while Congress-ruled states like Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, Delhi and Rajasthan had reservations. The matter even led to a heated discussion in a Cabinet Committee on security between Chidambaram and BCCI President and NCP chief Sharad Pawar. The force requirement stated by the Election Commission for polling was 21 lakh security personnel. The requirement for an IPL match is about 5,000 personnel. In Rajasthan, police officers say they could have easily pulled out forces from safe areas to secure venues. With IPL agreeing to hire private security forces, the security issues could have been sorted out but for lack of time, again because of backroom politics.

Maharashtra has created the most political heartburn. The Congress-NCP allies were hammering out a seat-sharing arrangement for the elections when the IPL was added to the negotiating table. While state home minister,